

Marking criteria for first and second year UG practical reports

Marks	Classification	Practical report
95	Exceptional 1 st	This write-up is close to the standard of articles found in academic journals. Analysis: Meets the criteria for an outstanding 1st but with additional innovation in, or understanding of, the data analytic tools applied to the research question. Critical Thinking: The student shows a high level of ability to criticise constructively both past research and the research that they have performed (both on methodological and theoretical grounds) and makes insightful and worthwhile suggestions for future research. Theoretical Understanding: The introduction and discussion show a firm understanding of the theoretical issues underlying the research. In particular, the introduction is a focused account of relevant work leading up to the study conducted, and the discussion demonstrates an insightful grasp of the theoretical implications of the work. Organization: It is an outstanding study and write-up that shows initiative, flair and originality. The write-up is exceptional in terms of clarity, organisation of material. Faultless adherence to project format conventions. Research/Design: There is evidence of wide, independent reading of relevant research (from up to date journal articles and books). Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, the design is outstanding in terms of originality, methodological rigour and theoretical significance.
82, 88	Outstanding 1 st	The study and write-up show initiative and originality. Analysis: Meets the criteria for a clear 1st but with exceptional clarity and coherence or perhaps shows a solid use and understanding of analytic tools beyond what has been taught. Critical Thinking: The student shows an excellent ability to criticise constructively both past research and the research that has been performed (both on methodological and theoretical grounds) and to make insightful and worthwhile suggestions for future research. Theoretical Understanding: The introduction and discussion show an excellent understanding of the issues underlying the research, and there is clear evidence that the student understands the theoretical implications of their work. Organization: The write-up is very well organised, and clearly written. The introduction is fairly focused and there is little evidence of wandering off on tangents. There are few errors in adherence to project format conventions. Research/Design: There is some evidence of independent reading of relevant research (from up to date journal articles and books). Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, the design is very good in terms of originality, methodological rigour and theoretical significance.

72, 75, 78	Clear 1 st	The study and write-up show some degree of originality and invention. Analysis: Excellent data analysis and presentation evidenced by a correctly-executed analysis that is appropriate to address the research question, and by a coherent presentation that implies a full understanding of visualizing, analysing, describing and interpreting data. Critical Thinking: The student shows some ability to make non-trivial criticisms of past research and of their own study (both on methodological and theoretical grounds) and to make insightful and worthwhile suggestions for future research. Theoretical Understanding: The student demonstrates a reasonable understanding of theoretical and methodological issue. The discussion shows a good understanding of the theoretical issues underlying the research. Organization: The write-up is well organised and clearly written. The introduction may be slightly less focused than for higher marking bands but largely avoids mentioning work not directly relevant to the current research. There can be minor errors in terms of adherence to project format conventions. Research/Design: There is evidence of some independent reading of relevant research (from up to date journal articles and books), supplementing references already provided on the reading list. Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, the design is good in terms of originality, methodological rigour and theoretical significance.
62, 65, 68	2.1	This is a basically sound project. Analysis: Competent data analysis and presentation that is evidenced by a correctly-conducted analysis that is appropriate to address the research question, and by a presentation that is generally coherent and implies a good understanding of visualizing, analysing, describing and interpreting data. Critical Thinking: The student makes some attempt to criticise constructively their own and past research (both on methodological and theoretical grounds) but these may contain some trivial observations. Sensible suggestions for future research are made. Theoretical Understanding: The discussion includes a competent attempt to relate the findings to previous theoretical and empirical research; however, the exposition of theoretical implications is less than in higher bands. Organization: The write-up is fairly well organised, and clearly written (possibly with some minor lapses of clarity). The introduction may not be as focused as in higher marking bands but the key relevant material is included. Some errors in adherence to project format guidelines will be tolerated. Research/Design: Background material used for the introduction and discussion does not go substantially beyond that mentioned on the reading list. Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, the student has produced a competently designed, methodologically rigorous study.

52, 55, 58	2.2	This is an adequate project. Analysis: Minor deficiencies in data analysis and presentation evidenced by an analysis that is partially inappropriate to address the research question and/or has some minor errors in execution, or by a presentation with occasional lapses in coherence and/or that implies confusion about visualizing, analysing, describing and interpreting data. Critical Thinking: An inability to constructively criticise their own or past research (either on methodological and theoretical grounds) or to suggest worthwhile future research. Theoretical Understanding: Limited attempt to relate the study to previous work (theoretical and empirical). Organization: This is an adequately organised and moderately competent project, but it may contain some of the following limitations: lack of adherence to standard format, poor organisation of material, poor or clumsy expression. Research/Design: Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, the design is adequate in terms of methodological rigour. Background material used for the introduction and discussion is limited to textbooks.
42, 45, 48	3 rd	This is a perfunctory attempt at writing up the project. Analysis: Moderate deficiencies in data analysis and presentation evidenced by an analysis that is inappropriate to address the research question and/or has some errors in execution, or by a presentation that lacks coherence and/or demonstrates little understanding of visualizing, analysing, describing and interpreting data. Critical Thinking: Little evidence of any ability to evaluate the theoretical or methodological limitations of the study performed. Theoretical Understanding: Little attempt to relate the results to relevant theoretical background material. Organization: Basic information about the research is communicated, but there is little attention to comprehensiveness or clarity in describing the procedures used or the results obtained. Scrappy presentation. Research/Design: Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, the design has some merit but has major methodological flaws or limitations that could have been foreseen and avoided.

35, 38	Marginal Fail	This is an unacceptable piece of work with some of the following shortcomings. Analysis: Serious deficiencies in data analysis and presentation as evidenced by an analysis that is inappropriate to address the research question and/or is incorrectly executed, or by a presentation that is cursory, extremely incoherent and/or demonstrates a lack of understanding of visualizing, analysing, describing and interpreting data. Critical Thinking: No evidence of any ability to evaluate the theoretical or methodological limitations of the study performed. Theoretical Understanding: Complete lack of theoretical insight. Organization: Incomplete or badly written up; very little effort put into describing the method, results and relevant background theory and research. Incoherence in presentation of background material, procedures or analysis; very poor presentation. Research/Design: Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, the design is inadequate to address the research issue.
0, 10, 20, 30	Absolute Fail	The project is seriously deficient in several respects. Analysis: No analysis attempted or one so ill-conceived as to demonstrate virtually no understanding of visualizing, analysing, describing and interpreting data. Critical Thinking: No attempt to evaluate the theoretical or methodological limitations of the study performed Theoretical Understanding: Complete lack of theoretical insight. Organization: There is barely any attempt to mention relevant background theory and research, and to describe the method and results. Research/Design: Where students have been required to design the study from scratch, either no study was conducted or it was so poorly conceived as to be of no consequence whatsoever for the research issue.